

The Transpersonal Approach to Coaching

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INTRODUCTION

The transpersonal is a level of consciousness where we admit that we are spiritual beings with a soul and a spirit. As we know from the work of Ken Wilber (2000), it is usual to distinguish between the pre-personal, the personal and the transpersonal. The personal is the ordinary everyday consciousness with which we are all familiar; the pre-personal is all that comes before that in the process of pre-natal and child development, and is well described in developmental psychology generally (Wilber, 2000); and the transpersonal is that which genuinely goes beyond the personal into the realm of the sacred, the numinous, the holy, the divine. It has often been pointed out that society helps us to develop out of the pre-personal into the personal, and even helps us through the early development of the personal into the mature ego that is favoured in our society generally. Society does not, however, help us on into the transpersonal. That is something for each person to initiate and take responsibility for.

Since the founding of the *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* in 1969, and the formation of the Association for Transpersonal Psychology (ATP) in 1972, the transpersonal has been studied scientifically, and in 1996 the British Psychological Society (BPS) founded the Transpersonal Psychology Section, which publishes the peer reviewed *Transpersonal Psychology Review*. This and the publication of a variety of books (e.g. Cortright, 1997; West, 2000; Wilber, 2000; Ferrer, 2002; Rowan, 2005), have made the subject respectable and well-based.

Examining the boundaries of the transpersonal should help to clarify the concept further.

The transpersonal is not the extrapersonal

A distinction has been drawn by Alyce and Elmer Green (1986) between the extrapersonal and the transpersonal. The point is that the extrapersonal can sometimes be a gift that the person has. It can simply be a wild talent, perhaps present from an early age. The whole range of the paranormal comes in here, as representing the extrapersonal.

The transpersonal is not the same as the right brain

There is a lot of interest these days in the two halves of the brain, and it is often said that our civilization neglects the right brain and overstresses the left brain. There may be something in this, and there is no wish here to pour cold water on the whole idea, but it is important to make the point that to locate the transpersonal in the right brain is a mistake. It is a mistake because it necessarily lumps the transpersonal with the pre-personal.

The transpersonal is not New Age

There is a good deal of interest these days in New Age, and in my travels I have seen whole sections of bookshops, and even whole bookshops, devoted to it. But the general attitude of New Age seems to be indiscriminating, and even to be against the whole idea of discrimination.

The transpersonal is not religion

The transpersonal is to do with personal experience, which may or may not be expressed in religious terminology. If it is expressed in some religious way, it is just as likely to be some little-known religion such as paganism, animism, polytheism or pantheism, as one of the more socially recognized religions. In other words, the transpersonal is a realm of personal discovery, not something which one joins.

The transpersonal is not the spiritual

Even more importantly, the word spirituality is used so vaguely and generally that we have to question its value. There can be 'pre-personal' spirituality (which includes fundamentalism and is often fear-based), personal spirituality (which produces all kinds of good works and humanitarian missions) and transpersonal spirituality. In the early 1970s Roberto Assagioli described the transpersonal as

a term introduced above all by Maslow and by those of his school to refer to what is commonly called spiritual. Scientifically speaking, it is a better word; it is more precise and, in a certain sense, neutral in that it points to that which is beyond or above ordinary personality. Furthermore it avoids confusion with many things which are now called spiritual but which are actually pseudo-spiritual or parapsychological. (Assagioli, 1991: 16)

I think this is a very important point, because the word 'spiritual' is beginning to be used much more these days as a catch-all, which could obscure the kinds of distinctions I am making here.

Within the transpersonal Within the transpersonal, there is an important distinction to be made, which I think is most clearly put by Wilber (2000). Transpersonal 1 is variously called the

Subtle, the realm of the soul, the superconscious, the heart centre, the intuitive mind, the psychic centre, the *antaratman* and so forth. Its distinguishing feature is that it shows forth the divine in the form of symbols and images, which are accessible and reasonably familiar to all. So it is the realm of archetypes (Shadow, Anima, Puer, etc.), deities, nature spirits, standing stones, wells, trees, rivers and so forth – all things which are accessible to all of us, and which point to the divine if approached in the right way. It is the realm of compassion of a deeply emotional kind. In coaching it is the realm of linking – a psychological connection with another person where the usual boundaries seem to fall away (Rowan, 2005).

Transpersonal 2 is the further stage of transpersonal development, where we are able to give up all symbols and images, all the comfortable distinctions and divisions, and move into the deep ocean of spirituality, where there are no signposts and no landmarks. This is variously called the Causal, the overmind, the bliss mind, the pure self, formless mysticism, the witness, cessation, the Void, Big Mind and so forth (Wilber, 2000). This is less often used in coaching, because it is much harder to attain, and therefore rarer as a resource.

However, Transpersonal 1 can be used quite readily, because it is more accessible and more coaches have had some experience of it, particularly if they have been through psychosynthesis training, where much attention is paid to it. Sir John Whitmore, for example has used ideas from psychosynthesis a good deal – ideas such as sub-personalities, guided imagery and the super-conscious (Whitmore & Einzig 2007). In what follows, I give examples of how it can be used in coaching.

Conditions for human development and obstacles for development in this tradition

The transpersonal tradition is devoted to the idea of development, and holds that we are all on a path of psychospiritual development whether we know it or not and whether we like it or not (Wilber, 2000). At the same time it recognizes that at the extreme point of development the whole idea disappears because it holds that the central part of a person was never born and will never die. This is part of the mystical tradition that we have named as Transpersonal 2. This tradition recognizes that people go through stages in their lives when predictable issues have to be faced and dealt with. What we do not do is to ascribe much importance to them except as illusions to be seen through. In fact, from a transpersonal point of view, the whole object of therapy is to get rid of illusions and false assumptions. Similarly with coaching; what holds people back is not the facts of their situations, but the false assumptions they make about them. As Mark Twain once said, ‘It is not the things we don’t know that hold us back, it is the things we do know for sure that just ain’t so!’

One of the main illusions, which has to be faced and dealt with, is the false belief that we are determined by our previous experiences. The word that is unfortunately too often used for this is ‘conditioning’, and this is believed in as a real entity with its own fixed laws. From a

transpersonal point of view, conditioning may well apply to rats and other organisms, but not to the human soul, which is unconditioned. This is certainly so at the level we have called Transpersonal 1, where we are more inclined to say that 'Wounds are for healing'.

However, there is an interesting contribution which has been made by Whitmore (2002). He suggests that people in business and elsewhere have two forms of development, which can get separated with unfortunate results. One is everyday development, which is objective, quantitative, psychological, out there – mainly concerned with what we have named as the personal: material things and socially approved achievements. He says that many people act as if this were all there is. The other is transpersonal development, which is more qualitative, aspirational, spiritual and mainly concerned with the inner world. He suggests that we look at these as two dimensions at right angles to each other. The horizontal dimension he calls the psychological/quantitative and the vertical dimension the spiritual/qualitative. This gives us a graphic space where we can plot the position of a given person at a given time. If a person were balanced between these two, we would get a neat diagonal line on such a graph, showing equal progress along both dimensions. But what so often happens is that a person, let us say a businessman, crawls along the bottom of the graph, paying much attention to the psychological/quantitative – or in other words, his work – but none or a minimal amount to the spiritual/qualitative. (Of course it would also be possible, if less common in our society, to pay attention only to the spiritual/qualitative dimension, and be equally unbalanced in that way.) But what may happen then is that the person hits a crisis of meaning. This very often takes the form of a break of some kind, forcing the person to rethink their whole life. It can then be a wake-up call, leading the person to take up coaching, for example as a way out. 'When we hit the crisis wall, we tend to bounce back in shock and into temporary confusion and performance regression for a while, but we are at the same time pulled upwards toward the ideal eventually to discover a more balanced path' (Whitmore, 2002: 123). This can then lead to increased wisdom in leading our life in a less one-sided and unbalanced way.

This means that people who come into transpersonal coaching as clients have often hit this wall. 'This crisis was typically associated with mid-life, but we are now seeing it among many younger people too' (Whitmore & Einzig, 2007: 126). In transpersonal coaching we are able to recognize such moments and help clients to use better maps of their world. Such development is not the gradual increase in ability which we found earlier on the path, but rather a step-function change, involving the rejection of much that we took for granted at earlier ages. It is here that the transpersonal can become important, as giving us the guideposts needed for the next phase of our development.

However, spiritual leaders often go wrong at this point in trying to help the person. They try to take the person straight to the highest realms of spirituality, instead of respecting the developmental path. Here Ken Wilber (2000) is a much better guide for people who need sustainable development. He recognizes that there are stages along the way which it is better to respect. The transpersonal is also a part of the journey in which there are no short cuts.

ESSENTIAL PROCESSES/DYNAMICS

From a transpersonal point of view, there are no fixed processes or dynamics, because everything is fluid and open to change all the time. It is a truly experimental point of view, which simply says – ‘Let’s try it and see’. Taking nothing for granted is easy at the level of Transpersonal 1, because we can now see that nothing is absolutely true. However, there is one theory which turns out to be particularly helpful at this stage. It is called ‘Theory U’ and it comes from the book *Presence* (Senge, Scharmer, Jaworski, & Flowers, 2005).

The idea is that in transpersonal work we are continually trying to engage with the creativity of the client. Our job is very often to help the client to bring out his or her latent creative spirit. One of the ways in which we can do that is by using Theory U. This postulates seven stages we have to go through with the client. We explain to the client that when we get to Stage 4, the full surge of his or her own creativity will come into play, because there is nothing getting in the way. Stages 1 to 3 are all about clearing out false or unnecessary assumptions, which do in fact get in the way.

Stage 1: *Suspending*. Here we take the client’s problem, opportunity or other issue and stand back from it. The slogan at this point is ‘observe, observe, observe’. The coach encourages the client to disengage from any usual or predictable way of seeing the world. It involves seeing our issue as if from a distance. It also involves unhitching our perception, so that it is not grabbed by events in the usual way. Patience is important at this stage, because the client is probably being asked to do something new.

Stage 2: *Redirecting*. This involves going down a level, so to speak, into the depths of our psyche. We can then begin to see from the whole, instead of the usual close-up vision, which is more partial. ‘Retreat and reflect’ is one slogan here. Funnily enough, this is actually more familiar for many people. One technique which I have used here is to ask the client to take the beliefs or assumptions which are getting in the way and simply ‘lay them aside for the moment’, like a package on the sofa or floor, which sounds quite unthreatening.

Stage 3: *Letting go*. In order to get here, we have to continue to spot and give up any false assumptions that we have been holding on to, perhaps unaware. Here the coach can be of great use in encouraging the client to let go further than he or she would normally. The great enemy of the voice of creativity is the voice of judgement, and the coach can encourage the client not to listen to this voice. And so we arrive at the deepest part of the U. It is a kind of cleared space. We are now able to be genuinely present for the first time.

Stage 4: *Letting come*. Now it is possible to allow something new to come in. This is something which was not envisaged at any earlier stage: it is radically new. It is truly creative. We have put aside anything that might get in the way of something genuinely fresh to come in. We are allowing what seeks to emerge. We welcome and admit it to the space we have cleared.

Stage 5: *Crystallizing.* Now comes the part where the new discovery has to become more sharp, more clear, more detailed. This is where the practical issues have to be dealt with. This is a very important part of the process; we are now coming up from the depth of the U.

Stage 6: *Prototyping.* Even more concrete and practical, we now try out definite experiments and trials. We try many different angles in order to get the best result possible. This is realizing the rough prototypes we came up with in the first place. And we are seeing them as living microcosms, rather than as mere instrumentalities. The coach can be very helpful at this point, again encouraging the client to persevere. ‘Act swiftly, with a natural flow’ is one slogan here.

Stage 7: *Institutionalizing.* Here we are finding the way to put resources behind what we have discovered, so that it may find its place in the world. This is the most practical and outward-looking part of the process.

We can see, therefore, that in transpersonal work we are not only ‘listening for the large life’ (Williams and Menendez, 2007), we are also listening for the deep life. It is certainly possible to say, with Dave Ellis, that ‘coaching gives the opportunity to think what they’ve not thought, say what they’ve not said, dream what they’ve not dreamt, and create what they’ve not created’ (Ellis, 1995).

Imagery

However, the main tools of the transpersonal coach are intuition and imagery. At the level of Transpersonal 1, intuition has become the main way of thinking, the main platform for interacting with the client and imagery is our main tool. Instead of saying ‘What happened in that meeting with your boss?’ we might say – ‘When you imagine that meeting with your boss, what is the image that comes to mind?’ And we then allow that answer to sink in to our consciousness and evoke a response in us. We enter into the imaginal world using our intuition.

Again, if a client has a problem with something or somebody, we can ask – ‘If that ... turned into an animal, what would that animal be?’ And if the person answers – ‘A rat’ – the next question is – ‘How do you feel about rats?’ This often leads to more insight into the nature of the problem. If the client produces an image spontaneously, we might become interested in what archetype it represented: at this level archetypes become very real. The anima and the animus, for example can be very much worthwhile exploring, as strongly affecting perception of a person or event (Woolger, 1990).

Dreams are not often mentioned in relation to coaching, but at this level dreams can be very useful in throwing light on everyday issues. The point of this is to undermine the client’s taken-for-granted way of seeing the world, and question radically the assumptions that are holding them back. This questioning also affects the issue of goals. Sometimes the client’s goals are just as dubious as any of the other assumptions which may be holding them back.

ROLE OF THE COACH AND RELATIONSHIP WITH A CLIENT

From a transpersonal point of view, the role of the coach is that of a companion along the way. There is no assumption of expertise, or leadership, or superiority in any way. It is more like a wise companion on a journey, who does not argue about the way, does not criticize any mistakes, encourages the weary, witnesses the struggles, does not really offer anything but a presence that is nourishing and warm.

The relationship is undemanding, supportive, realistic, truthful, observant and continually offering to go into different dimensions with the client. Williams and Menendez (2007: 152) say that ‘The power of a strong collaborative relationship cannot be underestimated’; but the transpersonal relationship goes further than that – it opens up a space in which both client and coach can coexist, in a deeply spiritual way. As Whitmore and Einzig (2007: 122) say, the client may be seen by the coach in the light of ‘Here is a soul who has challenges and obstacles to overcome on her journey through the university of life. This is another such learning opportunity’.

It is these other dimensions that make the difference between a transpersonal coach and some other kind. The coach might say: ‘What does your soul say about this?’ This would be an invitation to enter the Subtle realm (Transpersonal 1), as might be the simple question: ‘What image does that bring to mind?’ Even a basic question like: ‘Who would know the answer to that? Fact or fiction, past or present?’ would be likely to take the client into the subtle realm. The subtle realm allows for the possibility that the answer to a problem might lie outside a person, rather than inside them. It allows for the possibility of inspiration.

And when we come to Transpersonal 2 (if we ever do) all the symbols and images and archetypes disappear, and we are left with no signposts and no handrails and no landmarks. This can sometimes be accessed by such a simple question as: ‘What would an impersonal witness say about this?’ More commonly, the invitation would be to go to a place where there are no problems, and look at the issues from there. Suppose we dropped all the labels such as: ‘This is a problem’. ‘This not the way it should be’. ‘This is hurtful’. What if the situation just *Is*? From the phrase ‘This is wrong’, we simply drop the word ‘wrong’. This is a different dimension, and not every client is ready for this. But with the right person, at the right moment, it can hit a unique button not accessible by other means. This is quite different from the subtle, although both are within the transpersonal.

The transpersonal coach is both a rock and a serpent. At the subtle level, he/she is a serpent, wriggling round obstacles and not being stuck with a rigid answer to anything – a ‘feminine’ presence that encourages the client to work round so-called problems and not take anything for granted. At this level nothing is absolutely true, so it is easy to see other possibilities than the ones first presented. At the causal level the transpersonal coach is like a rock, with an unswerving solidity that makes the client feel supported in an unwavering way, with a steady compassion that does not fall short.

To understand the rock better, consider the Christian hymn which goes – ‘Rock of Ages, cleft for me, let me hide myself in thee’. At the subtle level this is the ability to use the coach as a resource, to take advantage of the deep solidity of the coach. At the causal level it becomes the

ability to become the rock oneself. Instead of depending on the rock, one may turn into the rock. The transpersonal coach can see both possibilities, and is not stuck with just one of them.

At a more prosaic level, the coach can simply call on the value of imagery. In the DVD of Whitmore and Einzig (2008), where the latter is coaching a client from the local government field, the coach deliberately encourages the client to bring up an image of a safe place, a place of peace and nourishment, for example. This is used later to help solve a problem for the client. And it is also clear from this example that the coach is really in there with the client, joining with the client in a common endeavour. The transpersonal coach is not an impartial observer, but a real participant in the action, risking his or her own presence in the act.

TASKS AND GOALS OF THE TRADITIONS

The main goal of the transpersonal coach is to enable clients to disengage from whatever beliefs are holding them back from their higher or deeper possibilities. In the transpersonal approach, the human mind is seen as infinite, and the human soul is divine, but most clients are not open to this perspective.

The task for the coach is to enable clients to work at the level most appropriate for them. It is said in therapy that some clients need glue, while others need solvent. This is also true in coaching. Some clients need help in consolidating their previous gains and finding more applications for what they know already. Other clients need help in getting rid of false assumptions and false trails, and finding new directions. Some clients need a combination of both – discovering for example the best ideas on negotiation, so as to yield the optimal result for all the parties involved. From a transpersonal perspective, everyone is right, and the trick is to enable the client to discover that, and to use such insights productively. Unlike New Age approaches, transpersonal coaching has a place for the negative, and recognizes that destruction has a value alongside creation, and is indeed part of the same process.

In fact, the kind of thinking found at the transpersonal level of functioning is very interesting in itself. It operates according to the laws of what Wilber calls vision-logic, and what others have called dialectical logic. It has also been called second-tier thinking. First-tier thinking is limited by the either/or: if I am right the other guy is wrong. In second-tier thinking I can be right and the guy who disagrees with me can be right too. Another way of putting this is to say that in second-tier thinking we start to see the value of paradox. The screen saver on my computer says: ‘Of course it matters. Of course it doesn’t matter. Of course it matters. Of course it doesn’t matter’ and so forth, endlessly. If I hold only ‘of course it matters’, I can get weighed down by responsibilities. If I hold only ‘of course it doesn’t matter’, I can be irresponsible and unreliable. But if I hold both, in suspension so to speak, then I am properly responsible but not weighed down by that.

The transpersonal approach adopts a sceptical attitude to the concepts of goals and tasks. At lower levels such ideas are very useful and indeed inevitable, but at the transpersonal levels

there is a radical questioning of such notions. People often come into transpersonal coaching at moments of crisis: 'It is the individual's ability to live through and be transformed by the crisis [from base metal to gold as in the alchemist's crucible] that differentiates the leader from the rest' (Whitmore & Einzig, 2007: 129).

This is not the language of goals and tasks – it is the language of transformation, and the language of the transpersonal: 'Having clear outcomes at the outset is one thing, but this type of work is much more organic and can often meander, diverge and reconnect as the client gains understanding of the next step on their change journey' (Coldman, 2007: 10).

In transpersonal coaching, in other words, we are more concerned with opening out possibilities than with finding answers to problems.

METHODS AND TECHNIQUES FOR FACILITATION OF CHANGE AND DEVELOPMENT

The transpersonal tradition is rich in techniques, because it is so open to creativity. Techniques are invented or modified in virtually every session. There is a particularly strong emphasis on imagery, as the imagination is seen as the best entry point for transpersonal insights. Very often there is much more trust in images than in words. Whitmore and Einzig have made the point that all the techniques of psychosynthesis are useful in transpersonal coaching (Whitmore & Einzig, 2007). Psychosynthesis is of course a well-established discipline in psychotherapy, and has made an impact wherever it has been used.

One of the most important techniques pioneered by psychosynthesis and often mentioned by Whitmore, for example is based on the idea that people are multiple rather than always just single. He uses the word sub-personalities to introduce this idea, but more recently the term I-positions has been found to carry fewer possibilities for misunderstandings and reification (Hermans, 2004).

Some coaches have told me that they cannot use the idea of I-positions in their work because they work on the phone and cannot see the client move about. But this is a false belief. I have certainly said to a phone client – 'See if you can imagine that woman sitting in a chair near you. Move the chair if it makes it easier. As you see her sitting there, how would you describe her?' That went all right, and I then went on to ask her to talk to the other person, and say all the things she really wanted to say. From there it was only a step to say – 'Now switch over and sit in the other chair and be her'. And this dialogue then carried on until a useful terminus was reached.

More important than any of these techniques, however, is the recognition that we are dealing here with a very specific level of consciousness, and that no-one will be able to use such methods convincingly if they have not had at least a glimpse of this level of consciousness, which Wilber (2000) calls the subtle, Hillman (2006) calls the soul, and which Cortright (2007) calls the psychic centre. Transpersonal work is not just about using certain methods, but also of

adopting this central outlook. And one way of attaining this state of consciousness is mindfulness (Passmore & Marianetti, 2007).

Some people are very reluctant to admit that they have a soul. There are many ways to get round this. One is simply to rename it: such terms as 'higher self', 'inner teacher', 'wise being', 'psychic centre' or even just 'heart' may be enough to make this acceptable. Another way is to use the concept from transactional analysis of the 'nurturing parent': it is not often realized that this concept contains most of the elements necessary to the soul. Like the soul, it is often neglected, and only needs to be brought into action by paying attention to it. Another way is to ask the client to think of someone they would really trust to have the answer or give understanding: I have had Sir Alex Ferguson, Sherlock Holmes, Aldous Huxley and many others standing in for this role. Simpler still is to ask the client to think of a stranger from another land who has been everywhere and seen everything, and has become very wise. What would this character say about the question?

Another technique is to ask the client to imagine something ideal and removed from the current scene. Williams and Memendez (2007) call this 'stepping into the future', and Whitmore and Einzig (2007) call it 'what makes your heart sing?' The client is asked to bring this to life as if it is happening now. When this has been done, the client is asked – 'What year, what month is it now?' When this has been answered convincingly, the next question is – 'What happened in the previous year to make that possible?' And so we go backwards until the present is reached, whereupon the client is asked to take the first step forward and see what that feels like.

APPLICATION TO SPECIFIC COACHING CONTEXTS AND GENRES

There seems little to be said about application of this approach to various genres and contexts of coaching. There are a few pioneers, such as Whitmore, who experiment in introducing the elements of transpersonal work in leadership coaching and in team coaching, but no research-supported publications are available that can give a reasonable review of such attempts. It could be argued that any context or genre of coaching (performance coaching, career coaching, life coaching) may have a transpersonal dimension in it if the mindset of the coach includes this dimension. However, this is yet to be proven. The developmental or transformational coach may have a particular interest in this approach.

EVALUATION OF THE TRADITION

The transpersonal tradition is so undeveloped in comparison with most of the other approaches to coaching that it is relatively hard to conduct a systematic or evidence-based evaluation of it. However, there is now a well-developed tradition of transpersonal research, and it is only a

matter of time before it is applied to coaching (Heron, 1996; Bentz & Shapiro, 1998; Braud & Anderson, 1998). One piece of research confirmed that intuition was highly cultivated in transpersonal therapists (Cameron, 2004). Instead of intuition being a chancy and momentary thing, the transpersonal coach relies heavily on intuition; it is the main way in which they think. This is quite a new way of experiencing intuition, but of course it takes time to build up the kind of trust which enables such things to emerge. Similarly, with the kind of deep empathy we have called linking, there is a kind of union with the client, and some say that an energy flow can be detected (Rowan & Jacobs, 2002; Cameron, 2004). Tobin Hart (1997) talks about this kind of transcendental empathy quite convincingly.

It is obvious, however, that the transpersonal approach is not for everyone. It suits best people who are creative and open to new ideas. It also suits people who have taken some steps in their own psychospiritual development, sufficient to have opened their eyes to the power of the imagination. Such people are more common nowadays, because we have gone beyond the old Jungian statement that such interests are only for the second half of life. Younger people are now waking up to the potential of the transpersonal in their lives.

FURTHER READING

- Rowan, J. (2005). *The transpersonal: Spirituality in psychotherapy and counselling* (2nd ed.). London: Routledge. (Gives the basic structure of the transpersonal, and warns against many of the most common errors in this area. Extensive material on actual practice.)
- Senge, P., Scharmer, C.O., Jaworski, J., & Flowers, B.S. (2005). *Presence: Exploring profound change in people, organizations and society*. London: Nicholas Brealey. (A ground-breaking book which is very readable and well presented.)
- Whitmore, J., & Einzig, H. (2007). Transpersonal coaching. In J. Passmore (Ed.), *Excellence in coaching*. London: Kogan Page.
- Useful statement of the original ideas behind transpersonal coaching.
- Wilber, K. (2000). *Integral psychology*. Boston, MA: Shambhala. (Ideal text on the transpersonal, giving all the research data on which his model is based.)

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